

of stuff to buy, and an ever-increasing pool of options for financing those purchases.

There's a real paradox around materialism in our culture, whereby what we can afford to buy and the lifestyle we have is deemed to be a measure of our success, but it's also often considered vulgar to covet material things. So, how can we service our desire for material things without accruing debt, clutter, or even just wasting money that we could use for other things on material possessions (that we only value up until the point that we own them)? There are a few different ways that we can manage this, all of which involve having a clear idea of the value that things hold for us, and what our priorities are.

The guidance I'd like to give first – and it was a real revelation to me when I hit upon it, even though it should be blindingly obvious – is that you can actually appreciate beautiful or appealing things without needing to own them. We're so used to being able to shop every image that we see on social media – encouraged, of course, by the retailers who are looking for ways to make absolutely everything shoppable – that we sometimes lose sight of the fact that we can appreciate a lovely living room or incredible outfit without actually needing to possess those products. The number of times that I've bought things that were of absolutely no use to me, didn't fit in my house or didn't suit my shape, just because I'd seen them looking great in another person's life doesn't bear thinking about. Can you think of any times when this has applied to